

# **DECODED**

# **EXPLAINED**

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**16th June, 2026**

### India, Slovakia expand ties with a slew of MoUs

Slovakia has continued to support India's quest for a permanent seat on the UNSC and "reaffirmed its constructive approach" to India's membership to the Nuclear Suppliers Group, as per the joint statement.

Defence and security cooperation would be "one of the key pillars" of the India-Slovakia relationship, as per the joint statement.

The two sides signed a Letter of Intent to promote defence cooperation – a move welcomed by Mr. Modi and Mr. Fico in their press statements. Through this framework, the governments would seek to collaborate more in defence technologies, defence industrial cooperation, capacity building, and research and development.

The two governments signed an MoU on digital technologies to provide structure to their digital cooperation, as they committed to deepening collaboration in AI, semiconductors and start-ups. They also agreed to explore cooperation in emerging fields, including the Internet of Things and 6G standardisation.

# India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties

- **The visit**
  - PM Modi visited Bratislava, Slovakia — the first-ever visit by an Indian Prime Minister since Slovakia's independence in 1993
  - Part of Modi's broader Europe visit (June 13-18, 2026), alongside the G-7 Summit in Évian
- **Comprehensive Partnership**
  - India and Slovakia branded their relationship a 'Comprehensive Partnership', with MoUs across defence, labour mobility, education and digital technology
  - A Letter of Intent was signed to promote defence cooperation covering defence technologies, industrial cooperation, capacity building and R&D
- **Digital and economic cooperation**
  - MoU on digital technologies to deepen collaboration in AI, semiconductors and start-ups; cooperation also flagged in IoT and 6G standardisation
  - Both sides committed to boost two-way trade in automotive, electronics and advanced manufacturing; the India-EU Free Trade Agreement was cited as an added boost
- **Strategic and multilateral support**
  - Slovakia reaffirmed support for India's bid for a permanent UNSC seat and for India's membership of the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG)
  - A Joint Working Group on Terrorism was formed; both sides condemned the April 2025 Pahalgam terror attack and called for UN/UNSC reform
- **People-to-people ties**
  - A social security agreement was agreed to facilitate labour mobility between the two countries
  - An MoU between the Higher Education Ministries to promote mobility of students and researchers, especially in STEM and humanities

# India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties

- **Slovakia**

- Borders and Location: It is a landlocked country in Central Europe bordered by five nations: Poland (North), Ukraine (East), Hungary (South), Austria (Southwest), and the Czech Republic (West).

- **Unique Capital:**

- Bratislava is the only national capital in the world that borders two sovereign states (Austria and Hungary).



## India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties

**MECR (Multilateral Export Control Regimes) are voluntary frameworks** aimed at preventing the proliferation of Weapons of Mass Destruction (WMDs) and restricting the transfer of sensitive technologies.

India is a member of 3 out of the 4 MECRs, except the NSG.

They function independently of the United Nations (UN). Their regulations apply only to members, and participation is voluntary.

## India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties

### **Australia Group (AG):**

AG was formed in 1985 as an informal forum of 43 countries aimed at **preventing the proliferation of chemical and biological weapons.**

The group helps members comply with the **Chemical Weapons Convention and Biological & Toxin Weapons Convention.**

**India joined it in 2018,** strengthening its position for membership in the NSG and advancing global non-proliferation objectives.

### **Missile Technology Control Regime (MTCR):**

MTCR is a **voluntary, informal partnership of 35 countries,** established in 1987, which aims to limit the **proliferation of missiles and unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs)** capable of **delivering WMDs.**

**It restricts the supply of such systems to non-members and is based on consensus decisions.**

India joined as the 35th member in 2016, gaining access to advanced missile technologies. Members are obligated to share military information and consult on exports.

## India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties

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## India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties

### **Wassenaar Arrangement:**

It aims to regulate the transfer of conventional arms and dual-use technologies.

It establishes lists of sensitive items for export controls to prevent destabilizing arms buildups and ensures that transfers do not enhance military capabilities that could undermine global stability.

Member countries are required to implement controls and report on the transfer of controlled items. India joined it in 2017.

### **Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG):**

NSG was formed in response to India's 1974 nuclear tests, aims to prevent nuclear proliferation by regulating nuclear and related exports.

It has 48 members and a Trigger List that restricts the export of certain nuclear items to non-nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) signatories.

India's NSG membership bid has been blocked by China, which calls for non-discriminatory procedures for countries outside the NPT and links India's entry to Pakistan's membership, despite Pakistan's ineligibility.

## **India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties**

### **Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty**

It is the only multilateral binding treaty for Nuclear-Weapon States (NWS) to disarmament while promoting peaceful nuclear energy use.

It defines NWS as countries possessing nuclear weapons before 1st January , 1967 (USA, UK, France, China, and USSR/Russia).

Non-nuclear states agree not to develop nuclear weapons, while nuclear states pledge not to transfer them.

It allows peaceful use of nuclear energy and provides a withdrawal option if national security is threatened.

Membership: 191 members with 5 NWS (US, Russia, UK, France & China).  
India is not a member.

## India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties

Monitoring: **International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) monitors compliance.**

**India and NPT:** India opposes the NPT, calling it discriminatory, as it legitimizes nuclear weapons for five countries while denying the same right to others.

India follows a **"No First Use" (NFU) policy** and is committed to global nuclear disarmament.

Other countries who are not members : Pakistan, North Korea, South Sudan, Israel

**Review is carried out every 5 years**

# India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties

What is/are the consequence/consequences of a country becoming a member of the 'Nuclear Suppliers Group'?

1. It will have access to the latest and most efficient nuclear technologies.
2. It automatically becomes a member of "The Treaty on the Non-proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT)".

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

This question was previously asked in

Official UPSC Civil Services Exam 2018 Prelims Part A

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1. 1 only
2. 2 only
3. Both 1 and 2
4. Neither 1 nor 2

Consider the following countries:

1. China
2. France
3. India
4. Israel
5. Pakistan

Which among the above are Nuclear Weapons States as recognized by the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons, commonly known as the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT)?

This question was previously asked in

UPSC Civil Services Exam (Prelims) GS Paper-I (Held On:...

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1. 1 and 2 only
2. 1, 3, 4 and 5 only
3. 2, 4 and 5 only
4. 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

## India and Slovakia Expand Bilateral Ties

Recently, the USA decided to support India's membership in multilateral export control regimes called the "Australia Group" and the "Wassenaar Arrangement". What is the difference between them?

1. The Australia Group is an informal arrangement which aims to allow exporting countries to minimize the risk of assisting chemical and biological weapons proliferation, whereas the Wassenaar- Arrangement is a formal group under the OECD holding identical objectives.
2. The Australia Group comprises predominantly of Asian, African, and North American countries, whereas the member countries of Wassenaar Arrangement are predominantly from the European Union and American continents. Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

# Iran-US Framework Pact: A Fragile Relief

## Iran-US framework pact is a relief. Work lies ahead

THE FRAMEWORK agreement between Iran and the US to negotiate a deal comes as a relief. Thousands of lives have been lost across West Asia in the last three-and-a-half months. Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz and the counter-blockade by the US triggered an economic shock, reminiscent of the Covid days. Oil prices have fallen, and stock markets worldwide have rallied after the announcement of the framework agreement. However, amid the optimism, it is important to remember that what has been agreed to is not a final deal but a framework to address longstanding issues. The prospect of a return to unrestricted shipping is heartening. But that, too, could take time to materialise and will depend on how safe shipping companies and insurers feel. Still, an open strait — through which roughly a fifth of the world's oil and gas passes — is good news. Its reopening, according to Trump, will depend on the signing of the final agreement, scheduled for Friday.

If the past two weeks are any indication, it takes very little for all sides to resume hostilities. Israel has already declared that it will not withdraw from Lebanon, while Tehran has demonstrated its willingness to call Tel Aviv's bluff and retaliate — militarily and by closing the Strait of Hormuz — if Lebanon is excluded from the terms of the ceasefire. Negotiating the details of Iran's nuclear programme, the release of frozen assets, sanctions relief, and securing the strait from future conflicts are even more difficult long-term challenges. For the US, a legitimate question, given that shipping through the Strait of Hormuz is only a return to the status quo ante, is: What exactly has Trump achieved? Republican hardliners have been opposing any deal short of a Carthaginian one, arguing that a compromise would weaken America's standing in the region. Israel, too, is deeply divided. Benjamin Netanyahu's far-right cabinet members have denounced the framework pact as a strategic failure. In Iran, hardliners within the IRGC oppose any agreement they perceive as surrendering leverage without securing meaningful guarantees, even as the country is in need of sanctions relief and reconstruction funding — both of which are unlikely to materialise without US acquiescence.

With millions of Indians working across the Gulf, thousands serving at sea, and households grappling with high fuel and LPG prices, the crisis is not a distant one for New Delhi. It should lend its support to the peace process. Without sustained engagement, the current pause risks becoming little more than an interlude in a cycle of instability.

# Iran-US Framework Pact: A Fragile Relief

- **The agreement**
  - Iran and the US reached a framework agreement to negotiate a full deal, after over three-and-a-half months of conflict across West Asia
  - Comes after Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz and a US counter-blockade caused an economic shock; oil prices fell and stock markets rallied on the news
- **What remains unresolved**
  - This is a framework, not a final deal — details of Iran's nuclear programme, frozen assets, sanctions relief, and securing the Strait are still to be negotiated
  - Reopening of the Strait depends on the signing of a final agreement
- **Strategic significance of the Strait**
  - Roughly one-fifth of the world's oil and gas trade passes through the Strait of Hormuz
  - Its closure triggered an economic shock described as 'reminiscent of the Covid days'
- **Domestic political divisions**
  - Israel: Netanyahu's far-right cabinet members have denounced the pact as a strategic failure; Israel has said it will not withdraw from Lebanon
  - Iran: IRGC hardliners oppose any deal seen as surrendering leverage without guarantees, even as Iran needs sanctions relief and reconstruction funding
  - US: Republican hardliners argue any compromise short of total victory weakens America's regional standing
- **Relevance for India**
  - Millions of Indians work across the Gulf and thousands serve at sea; households face high fuel and LPG prices
  - India has a direct stake in supporting the peace process, given this economic and diaspora-related exposure

## Iran-US Framework Pact: A Fragile Relief

It is a narrow waterway between Iran and the Arabian Peninsula, specifically the United Arab Emirates, and Musandam (Oman).

The Gulf of Oman is on the strait's east, while the Persian Gulf is on the west.

It is the only sea channel linking the oil-rich Persian Gulf (west) with the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea (southeast).



## **Iran-US Framework Pact: A Fragile Relief**

Ships from which of the following countries have to cross the Strait of Hormuz to reach out to the Indian Ocean (Prelims 2026)

1. Bahrain
2. Syria
3. Qatar
4. Egypt

Which of the following is/correct

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) 1 and 3
- (c) 2 and 3
- (d) 3 and 4

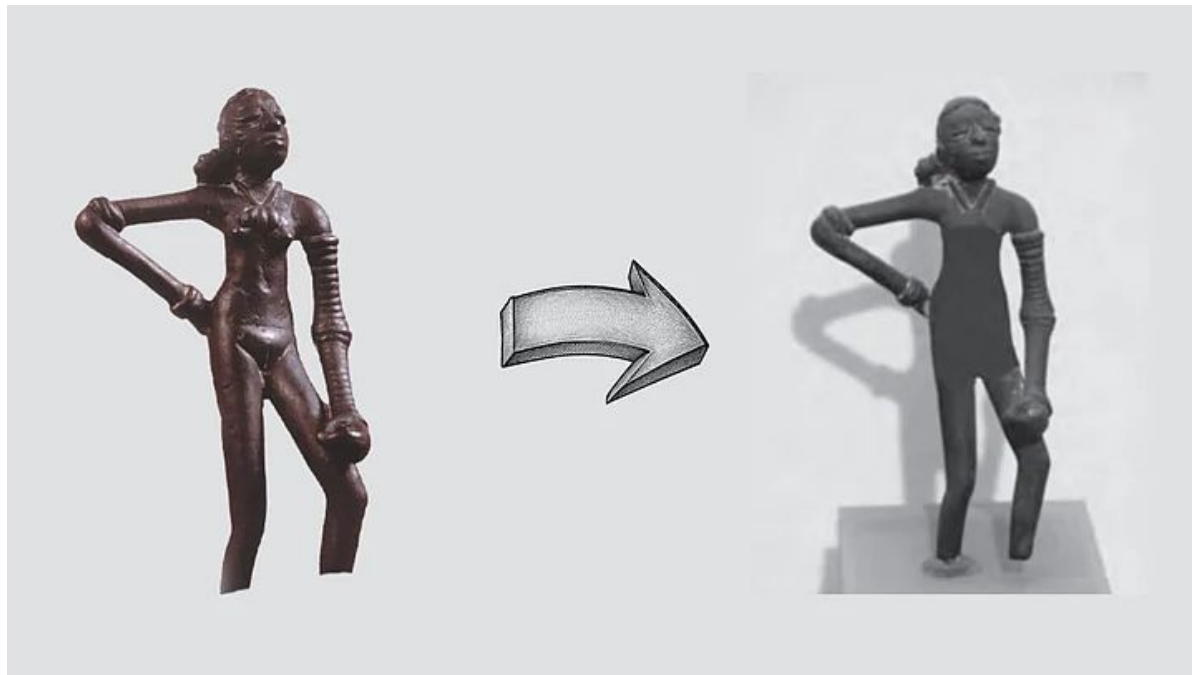
# NCERT Modifies 'Dancing Girl' Image in Textbook

## Dancing Girl, meet modest imagination

**W**HAT DOES the Dancing Girl of Mohenjo-daro — the 4,500-year-old bronze artefact on display at Delhi's National Museum — denote? The refinement of the Harappan civilisation, of course; its sophisticated knowledge of metallurgy. But also, the NCERT now seems to insist, immodesty. The inaugural Class IX art education textbook features an image of the figurine with its bare torso covered with a sheath, ostensibly to make it age-appropriate. The Dancing Girl has featured in NCERT's history textbooks for over 25 years before this. The move is remarkable not just for its prudishness but for what it reveals about pedagogical philosophy: That students must be protected from complexity, ambiguity, and the full texture of their own civilisation.

In recent years, through successive revisions, textbooks have been streamlined, historical emphases reordered and contentious subjects pared back. NCERT has cited a need for rationalisation of syllabi, and what its director D P Saklani said in 2024, justifying the deletion of the Gujarat riots and the violence after the Babri Masjid demolition from the Class XII Political Science textbook: "To create positive citizens, not violent and depressed individuals." The altered Dancing Girl belongs to the same sensibility. Instead of trusting students to understand context — that artistic nudity in an archaeological artefact is neither scandalous nor unusual — it removes the possibility of the encounter altogether. This sits uneasily with the NEP's ambition of fostering critical thinking: Education that aspires to cultivate independence of thought must make room for knowledge and context, not smoothen out every faultline, conflict and contradiction.

The impulse is also striking for what it communicates about women and their place in public life. At a time when more women than ever before are entering universities, workplaces, politics, and other public institutions, wearing their individuality in thought and attire, claiming spaces that often remain unequal or unwelcoming, the decision to cover up one of the most celebrated examples of ancient South Asian art sends an unfortunate message. The Dancing Girl has been significant not because it conforms to a blindfolded standard of modesty but because it embodies poise, confidence and unmistakable presence. If the task of education is to equip young people to engage with the world as it is, then NCERT would do better to trust both students, and women — both contemporary and millennia old — with a little more agency.



# NCERT Modifies 'Dancing Girl' Image in Textbook

- **What happened**
  - Class IX art education textbook shows the Dancing Girl of Mohenjo-daro figurine with its bare torso covered by a sheath, ostensibly to make it age-appropriate
  - The figurine had featured uncovered in NCERT history textbooks for over 25 years before this change
- **Part of a wider pattern**
  - NCERT has cited a need for 'rationalisation of syllabi' for recent textbook revisions
  - In 2024, content on the Gujarat riots and post-Babri Masjid demolition violence was deleted from the Class XII Political Science textbook, justified as creating "positive citizens, not violent and depressed individuals"
- **About the artefact**
  - A 4,500-year-old **bronze** figurine from the Harappan civilisation, reflecting its sophisticated knowledge of metallurgy
  - On display at the National Museum, New Delhi
- **Why it matters**
  - Critics argue this reflects a pedagogical philosophy of shielding students from complexity, ambiguity, and the full texture of their own civilisation
  - Seen as sitting uneasily with the NEP's stated ambition of fostering critical thinking and independence of thought
  - Raises questions about how art, the body, and women's agency are represented in public education

## NCERT Modifies 'Dancing Girl' Image in Textbook

**Q. The famous female figurine known as 'Dancing Girl', found at Mohenjo-daro, is made of:**

(a) Carnelian

(b) Clay

(c) Bronze

(d) Gold

# Centre issues alert on potential drone attacks on vital installations

**S. Vijay Kumar**  
CHENNAI

The Union government has warned of possible rogue drone attacks targeting vital installations along the borders, prompting security agencies to work on deploying counter-drone technology systems to safeguard critical assets across the country.

According to official sources, the Marine Security Wing of the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways issued the alert on the emerging drone threat at Vital Assets and Vital Installations (VAVIs) located around the land and sea borders. It was stated that the current geo-political

situation across the world had demonstrated that hostile drones could disrupt operations of critical VAVIs. "There is an urgent need to take concrete steps to safeguard our assets, especially those located near the borders from rogue drones by installing Anti-Drone Systems," the communication said.

The Ministry of Home Affairs had constituted the Anti Rogue Drone Technology Committee in the Border Security Force for evaluation and certification of new technology systems.

The Central Industrial Security Force had also formed a Sub-Committee Board of Officers to carry out surveys of VAVIs.

## Centre Alerts on Rogue Drone Attacks on VAVIs

- The alert
  - The Union government warned of possible rogue drone attacks targeting **Vital Assets and Vital Installations (VAVIs)** along land and sea borders
  - Issued by the Marine Security Wing, Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways
- Why now
  - The current geopolitical situation worldwide has shown that hostile drones can disrupt operations of critical VAVIs
  - Urgent need flagged to safeguard border-located assets by installing Anti-Drone Systems
- Institutional response
  - MHA has constituted the **Anti Rogue Drone Technology Committee** under the **Border Security Force (BSF), for evaluation and certification of new counter-drone technology**
  - The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) has formed a Sub-Committee Board of Officers to carry out surveys of VAVIs
- Significance
  - Reflects growing institutionalisation of counter-drone preparedness within India's internal security architecture
  - Complements wider efforts on critical infrastructure protection along the borders

# Drone Revolution and Modern Warfare

## Drone revolution and modern warfare

The wars in Ukraine, Lebanon and West Asia have shown how drones have become central to modern warfare, as cheap, mass-produced unmanned systems proliferate, military power is increasingly shaped by industrial scale, technological adaptation and the ability to build, deploy and counter drones

### EXPLAINER

Rahul Bahl

**F**or decades, military power has been defined by the scale and sophistication of conventional assets—combat aircraft, tanks, artillery, warships, air defence systems, precision-guided missiles, and other high-end assets.

**End of superiority**  
In this environment, battlefield superiority belonged to armies with technologically advanced platforms and equipment, sophisticated intelligence networks, and large budgets. Smaller militaries and non-state actors, by contrast, were largely confined to asymmetric tactics that relied on guerrilla warfare, ambushes, and other unconventional methods to offset their opponents' superior firepower and operational dominance.

But the ongoing wars in Ukraine and Lebanon, together with the wider U.S.-Israel-Iran theatre of conflict, have increasingly shattered this paradigm, demonstrating that commercially derived drones—mass-produced at scale, rapidly reconfigured for multiple operational roles, and widely deployed—have become a defining feature of contemporary warfare. Performing functions ranging from intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) and target acquisition to precision strikes, artillery spotting, electronic warfare, and logistics support, they have evolved from auxiliary assets into central instruments of military operations.

In doing so, they have transformed the 20th-century battlefield into an environment of persistent visibility and rapid engagement, where lines remain constantly exposed, and no area can no longer be assumed secure, multiple types of **thinned-out killing systems** (like the loiter, track, and strike targets) with unprecedented speed and precision.

Across these concurrent theatres of conflict, the widespread—and in some cases, deliberate—employment of drones has challenged established assumptions about how military power is generated and applied, reshaping doctrine, force structure, and future warfare's emergence. This convergence has been the convergence of a continuous and iterative process, with each war's position a study beyond much, and no single war offering a complete picture. It remains unclear for now, as detection is increasingly followed by rapid engagement and destruction.

### Ukraine drone war

Nowhere has the transformation been more visible than in Ukraine, where Russia's Special Military Operation launched in February 2022, as a conventional war involving tanks, aircraft, tanks and artillery, evolved within two years into the world's first industrial-scale, drone-intensive conflict.

From the outset stages of the conflict, Ukraine rapidly adopted commercially available drones—originally designed for civilian purposes with an aerial photography, mapping, and basic surveillance—despite a limited number of early military **Unmanned Aerial Vehicle (UAV)** assets (PB-70 improved reconnaissance and strike systems).

What had initially functioned as a support tool for intelligence gathering and



From the outset stages of Russia's invasion, Ukraine adapted commercially available drones, to a major

guiding artillery fire quickly evolved into a decisive combat capability, as small quadcopters—off-the-shelf Hobby King FPV drones—were progressively weaponised and deployed as low-cost, precision-guided munitions. This shift marked a fundamental transformation in how unmanned systems were used on the battlefield, from passive information gathering platforms to active instruments of destruction. By around 2024, drones had become fully integrated into almost every layer of Ukrainian combat, ranging from tactical battlefield surveillance to frontier targeting and deep-strike missions against logistics hubs, supply routes, and rear-area infrastructure.

The operational template that emerged from this experience in Ukraine was subsequently replicated, albeit in varying degrees and in different forms, across the continuing West Asian conflict, underscoring the growing centrality of drones to contemporary warfare.

### FPV revolution

At the heart of Ukraine's drone revolution is the FPV (first-person view) system—an inexpensive, commercially available platform originally designed for recreational hobby and aerial photography. Conceived through a series of open-source projects, these FPV systems were built by hobbyists, not engineers, and their operation, FPV pilots rely on exceptional persistence, manoeuvrability, and responsiveness. These three elements translated into a broad spectrum of combat systems, including FPV strike drones, reconnaissance drones, interceptors, and long-range attack systems.

Ukraine's drone war has been a series of heavy-lift heavyweights Vanya drone—nicknamed "Vanya" (big) by Russian forces after the famous figure from Fyodor Dostoevsky's novel—equipped with improved modular platforms.

The most common are FPV Lancet or strike drones, inexpensive quadcopters carrying explosive payloads such as modified rocket propelled grenades (RPGs) or precision-built warheads, and down directly into targets as disposable precision-guided missiles. Their extremely low cost has radically reduced battlefield attrition, with systems worth only a few hundred dollars to destroy armoured vehicles and equipment valued in the millions.

These systems operate within a broader Ukrainian deep-strike drone architecture that includes loitering munitions such as **Bayraktar TB3** and **Shahed 136**. The latter functions as an aerially deployed "parasite drone," carried by the Ukrainian-designed multi-purpose **Shahed 136** Airborne long-range UAVs, enabling the penetration of contested airspace under intensive electronic warfare conditions and extending operational reach. **Bayraktar TB3**, by contrast, is a short-range precision loitering munition employed in coordination with reconnaissance drones like the locally developed **Shahed 136** with improved variants offering greater range and endurance to expand their strategic and tactical envelope against air defence systems and rear-area targets.

Also included within Ukraine's expanding drone inventory are loitering drones—largely adapted from commercial **UAVs** (like the **Shahed 136**)—which are modified for aerial photography, mapping and industrial applications—while early and improved versions, which carry and deliver precision-guided munitions, strike targets, and can conduct multiple sorties, making them particularly effective against trucks, bunkers, and other static positions.

Among the most advanced FPV-based systems is the **Paganin** FPV, a long-range, on-war attack drone designed to strike deep inside Russian territory against critical hubs, airbases, and critical infrastructure, far beyond the tactical horizon. In practice, however, the distinction between FPV strike drones and loitering munitions has become increasingly blurred, with many FPV-based systems now equipped with long-range loitering capabilities.

But Ukraine's most significant modification has been the emergence of **FPV strike drones**, an adaptation of the **FPV** system, which is a UK-made conventional drone, which is modified to carry a precision-guided warhead. These platforms transmit their data via a dedicated radio link, rather than the traditional FPV video feed, enabling them to operate in highly contested environments. In heavily contested operational environments, this capability represents a significant operational advantage to its operators, enabling missions to be conducted

### largely free from electronic disruption.

### Regional drone networks

Meanwhile, unlike Ukraine, Hezbollah's offensive UAV capability is primarily built around Iranian-supplied platforms with limited local modification, relying heavily on systems like **Ababil**, **Shahed**, and **Shahed 136**. These platforms provide a layered operational architecture, spanning ISR and strike functions. Within this framework, the **Ababil** and **Shahed 136** provide tiered ISR coverage across mediums to front ranges, while the **Shahed 136** loitering munition fulfils a "dedicated" one-way strike role across a wider regional theatre.

More recently, Hezbollah has also adopted jamming-resistant three-optic FPV drones, enabling operations in heavily contested electromagnetic environments and enhancing close-range reconnaissance and precision strike effectiveness despite extensive Israeli EW measures.

In response, the **Israel Defense Forces (IDF)** in Lebanon have developed a **Forward Counter-Drone** architecture, integrating EW systems, specialised radar arrays, and experimental platforms like the AI-enabled **Iron Tower** radars. Designed to neutralise low-altitude UAVs through kinetic, non-explosive interception methods such as net capture by which a physical net is deployed to entangle and disable an incoming drone, mid-air—or direct collision, rather than solely missile engagements. Meanwhile, the **IDF** operates a multi-tiered UAV force structure combining kinetic endurance drones for persistent fill with armed drones for striking munitions integrated into reconnaissance strike complexes for precision engagement.

But, for its part, counting a third and structurally distinct model of drone

Rather than employing drones solely as tactical assets, the **Israeli** **Iron Tower** Guard Corps (IBTC) integrates them into a broader strategy of deterrence, coercion, and power projection against the U.S.-Israel combine and their regional partners across West Asia.

Through indigenous systems such as **Shahed** drone variants, alongside platforms supplied by proxy forces across Iran, Syria, Lebanon, and Yemen, the **IDF** has demonstrated an ability to transform military power, critical infrastructure, and rear assets across West Asia to relatively low cost.

### Economy shift

This, across ongoing wars and conflicts, the drone revolution is driving a major, by economic as technology. Cheap, mass-produced unmanned systems are rapidly replacing legacy logistics, and specialised military weapons, shifting the advantage toward the scale, speed, and production capacity of UAV ecosystems.

Warfare, therefore, is increasingly being shaped by a new industrial order and nonlinear technological adaptation, where success hinges on the ability to build, deploy, and counter fast-evolving, increasingly reconfigured drone networks. In this rapidly evolving battlefield, where there are no longer any unquestioned layers of infrastructure of modern day war—shipping lanes, conflict are uncharted, fought, sustained, and ultimately decided.

Rahul Bahl is a journalist based in New Delhi and Chennai specialising in military, defence and security matters

### THE GIST

#### ➤

Ukraine has pioneered industrial-scale drone warfare, integrating FPV drones, loitering munitions, heavier drones and three-optic systems across reconnaissance, targeting and deep-strike missions.

#### ➤

Low-cost FPV strike drones have transformed battlefield economics, enabling systems worth a few hundred dollars to destroy armoured vehicles and equipment valued in the millions.

#### ➤

The widespread adoption of drones has challenged traditional assumptions about military power, creating a continuous battlefield where detection is increasingly followed by rapid engagement and destruction.

# Drone Revolution and Modern Warfare

- **End of conventional superiority**
  - Wars in Ukraine, Lebanon, and the wider US-Israel-Iran conflict show cheap, mass-produced drones can offset traditional military advantages
  - Drones now perform ISR, precision strikes, artillery spotting and electronic warfare not just auxiliary roles
- **Regional drone networks**
  - Hezbollah's offensive capability is built largely around Iranian-supplied platforms (Shahed, Mohajer series)
  - Israel's IDF has developed a layered counter-drone architecture — EW systems, radar arrays, and the AI-enabled 'Iron Drone Raider' using net-capture interception
  - Iran's IRGC integrates drones into a broader strategy of deterrence and regional power projection
- **Economic shift in warfare**
  - Drones costing a few hundred dollars can destroy armoured vehicles and equipment worth millions, transforming battlefield economics
  - **Military power increasingly depends on industrial scale and the ability to build, deploy and counter drones, not just expensive legacy platforms**

# **Drone Revolution and Modern Warfare**

## **Policy Recommendations for India**

### **Build large drone manufacturing capacity**

Not depend on imports.

### **Develop anti-drone systems**

To detect and destroy enemy drones.

### **Use AI and electronics**

Because future wars will depend as much on software as on weapons.

### **Prepare for swarm attacks**

Particularly from adversaries that may deploy large numbers of drones.

# Technology Drives India-France Strategic Convergence

## Technology drives India-France strategic convergence

It is a measure of the importance that Prime Minister Narendra Modi and French President Emmanuel Macron attach to the India-France relationship that they are meeting again in France, on the sidelines of the G-7 Summit in Evian (June 15-17), barely months after Mr. Macron's visit to India for the India AI Impact Summit 2026 in New Delhi in February. During that visit, the two leaders jointly inaugurated the India-France Year of Innovation 2026.

In normal diplomacy, such announcements often take time to translate into action. It is therefore notable that Mr. Modi and Mr. Macron are already moving swiftly to advance bilateral technology cooperation. They jointly inaugurated the "Bharat Innovates" event in Nice (June 14-16), bringing together leading Indian start-ups and venture capital funds. Mr. Modi will then attend the VivaTech Summit in Paris on June 18, Europe's largest technology and start-up event, underscoring the growing India-France technology partnership.

### The new pillars of partnership

The India-French relationship is constantly evolving and is consequently being updated by the two leaders who are committed to the cause.

While the recently elevated Special Global Strategic Partnership has always included traditional areas such as defence, nuclear and space, it is the focus on tech and innovation that is now exciting for the relationship.

This focus will include cyberspace, Artificial Intelligence (AI), health care, sustainable development, creative economy, education and research. These are new facets of the evolving and dynamic relationship and will no doubt take



**Mohan Kumar**

Former Indian Ambassador to France and now Dean/Professor at O.P. Jindal Global University

Technology and innovation power the next phase of India-France ties

ties to greater heights. Tech and innovation has tremendous mutual advantages for both sides. France has some of the best state-of-the-art technology in aerospace, AI, robotics, biotech, health care, green tech and sustainable development, besides being a European hub for the digital economy.

It is not hard to see how India can not only benefit from access to technology in these areas but also bring its own added value in terms of frugal innovation, start-ups, digital public infrastructure and biotech, just to name a few. The possibilities are endless. It must be hoped that the two tech summits – "Bharat Innovates" and the "Vivatech" – will enable the private sector on both sides to come up with substantive collaborative arrangements.

### Defence, space and Africa

The two leaders are also expected to take stock of the special strategic partnership. There are a number of dossiers which can benefit from their political and strategic guidance. The first is certainly the idea of the co-designing and co-production of defence platforms which must be expedited. Progress is also desirable in emerging areas such as small modular reactors, joint satellite development and human flight programmes.

The potential for Franco-Indian cooperation in Africa has not been fully exploited and this must get the attention of both sides. This becomes even more important in light of the postponement of the India-Africa Forum Summit (May 2026) due to the Ebola crisis in Africa. The two leaders will doubtless exchange views on the ongoing conflicts: in Ukraine and in Iran, which have

adversely and disproportionately affected countries of the Global South.

Mr. Modi's Europe visit (June 13-18, 2026) also includes a state visit to Slovakia, the first-ever visit by an Indian Prime Minister to Slovakia since its independence in 1993.

### Watching the 'D10 debate'

France, as the current chair of the G-7, will host the G-7 summit in Evian from June 15 to 17, 2026. It is difficult to imagine a G-7 summit without India being invited, and Mr. Modi's participation is particularly important given the geopolitical turbulence of the present moment. United States President Donald Trump is also expected to attend it. While attention will naturally focus on the possibility of a Modi-Trump meeting, any interaction may not be a substantive one, given the G-7 atmospherics.

More important is the evolving role of the G-7 itself in global geopolitics. With the G-20 having lost some of its momentum in recent years, discussions have resurfaced about expanding the G-7 into a D10 – a grouping of 10 major democracies. Whether, and how soon, such a transformation materialises remains uncertain, but it is a development India will need to watch closely.

At the end of the day, two middle powers – India and France – which set great store by strategic autonomy, have a fundamental role to play in contributing to geopolitical stability and ensuring a smooth transition to a multipolar world. In that sense, Mr. Modi and Mr. Macron shoulder a significant responsibility.

*The views expressed are personal*

# Technology Drives India-France Strategic Convergence

- The visit
  - PM Modi and President Macron met in France on the sidelines of the G-7 Summit in Évian (June 15-17, 2026)
  - Comes months after Macron's February 2026 visit to India for the AI Impact Summit, where the two jointly inaugurated the **India-France Year of Innovation 2026**
- New pillars of partnership
  - **The Special Global Strategic Partnership has traditionally covered defence, nuclear and space focus is now expanding to tech and innovation**
  - **Includes cyberspace, Artificial Intelligence, healthcare, sustainable development, the creative economy, and education**
- Key events
  - **'Bharat Innovates' event** in Nice (June 14-16) brought together Indian start-ups and venture capital funds
  - PM Modi attended the **VivaTech Summit in Paris (June 18) : Europe's largest technology and start-up event**
- Defence, space and Africa
  - Discussions on co-design and co-production of defence platforms, small modular reactors, joint satellite development, and human spaceflight programmes
  - Potential for Franco-Indian cooperation in Africa remains under-exploited; the India-Africa Forum Summit (May 2026) was postponed due to the Ebola crisis
- G-7, D-10 and India's role
  - France currently chairs the G-7; India's participation is seen as important given the present geopolitical turbulence
  - **Renewed debate on expanding the G-7 into a 'D10' (10 major democracies), amid the G-20 losing momentum**

## Technology Drives India-France Strategic Convergence

- Britain had proposed a 'D10' club of democratic countries that can be grouped with the G7 nations. These are Australia and the Asian technology leaders South Korea and India
- UK decided to pursue top 10 democracies of the world as an alternative to 5G equipment and technologies so as to avoid reliance on China's telecom giant Huawei.

## Older Persons Bearing the Brunt of Climate Change

# Older persons are increasingly bearing the brunt of climate change, finds study

**The Hindu Bureau**  
BENGALURU

Older persons in rural India are increasingly bearing the brunt of climate change, with heatwaves, floods and droughts compounding existing challenges of poor health, financial insecurity, and social isolation, according to a study released by HelpAge India on Monday.

The report, *Climate Resilient Ageing- Ensuring Care, Dignity and Agency*, released in Bengaluru on World Elder Abuse Awareness Day, surveyed 2,224 elderly persons across 20 districts in 10 States.

It found that 78% of respondents had experienced



Pension was the primary source of income for 49% of respondents, 16% reported not having any source of income. FILE PHOTO

at least one climate-related hazard in the last three years, with heatwave (45%), flood (27%) and drought (20%) being the most commonly reported events. More than one-third of those affected said climate events had a mod-

erate to severe impact on their lives.

The study noted that older persons living alone, widows, those aged over 80 years, and individuals with cognitive, communication or mental health difficulties faced dispropor-

tionately higher risks.

Heat stress emerged as a major concern. Nearly 60% of respondents said their homes were not fully safe during extreme heat conditions. While 90% reported staying indoors, 74% experienced illness, and 44% reported worsening of existing health conditions.

The study highlighted significant health and economic vulnerabilities. More than half (52%) said they were unable to afford essential medicines.

While pension was the primary source of income for 49% of respondents, 16% reported having neither employment nor any source of income.

# Older Persons Bearing the Brunt of Climate Change

- **The study**
  - HelpAge India released 'Climate Resilient Ageing – Ensuring Care, Dignity and Agency' on World Elder Abuse Awareness Day
  - Surveyed 2,224 elderly persons across 20 districts in 10 States
- **Key findings**
  - 78% of respondents had experienced at least one climate-related hazard in the last three years
  - Heatwave (45%), flood (27%) and drought (20%) were the most commonly reported events
  - More than one-third of those affected said the events had a moderate to severe impact on their lives
- **Health and economic impact**
  - Nearly 60% said their homes were not fully safe during extreme heat; 74% experienced illness, 44% reported worsening of existing health conditions
  - 52% said they were unable to afford essential medicines; 16% reported having neither employment nor any source of income
  - Pension was the primary source of income for 49% of respondents
- **Most vulnerable groups**
  - Older persons living alone, widows, those above 80 years, and individuals with cognitive, communication or mental health difficulties face disproportionately higher risks

*Thank you*